

FAIL

1. Passage anchor

> “...sometimes we are so busy chasing what might have been that we **fail to see** the value of what is already in front of us.”

Passage meaning

fail to do something = not do something that should, could, or was expected to happen

未能做某事；沒有做到某事

Here:

fail to see the value

= **沒有看見 / 未能意識到其價值**

The speaker does not mean “fail” in the sense of losing an exam or being unsuccessful overall. It means **not managing to notice or recognize something**.

Practice

1. We sometimes **fail to notice** what is already going well.
我們有時會**沒有注意到**已經進展順利的事情。
2. He **failed to understand** how important the decision was.
他**未能理解**這個決定有多重要。

Core meanings of FAIL

2. fail — not succeed

= be unsuccessful in achieving something

失敗；沒有成功

Examples

1. The plan **failed**.
計畫**失敗了**。
2. Their first attempt **failed**.
他們第一次嘗試**沒有成功**。

This is the central broad sense.

3. fail at something

= be unsuccessful in doing or performing something

在.....方面失敗；做不好

Examples

1. He **failed at** his first business venture.

他第一次創業**失敗了**。

2. She was afraid of **failing at** the task.

她害怕把這項任務**做失敗**。

Fail to do

4. fail to do something

= not manage to do something, or not do something expected or required

未能做某事；沒有做到某事

This is the exact passage branch.

Examples

1. He **failed to notice** the warning sign.

他**沒有注意到**警告標誌。

2. The report **fails to explain** the cause clearly.

報告**未能清楚解釋**原因。

5. fail to see / realize / understand

= not recognize or understand something

沒有看出；未能意識到；未能理解

Examples

1. People sometimes **fail to see** the bigger picture.

人們有時會**看不到更大的整體局勢**。

2. She **failed to realize** how serious the problem was.

她**沒有意識到**問題有多嚴重。

This is especially important for the passage.

Tests / exams

6. fail — not pass an exam/test

= receive an unsuccessful result in an examination, test, course, etc.

不及格；考試失敗

Examples

1. He **failed the exam**.

他考試**不及格**。

2. She was worried that she might **fail**.

她擔心自己可能會**不及格**。

Major learner sense.

7. fail someone

Especially BrE:

= give someone an unsuccessful grade

判某人不及格；讓某人肥佬

Examples

1. The examiner **failed him**.

考官判他**不及格**。

2. She was **failed** because her work did not meet the standard.

她因作品未達標而被判**不及格**。

Machine/system stops working

8. fail — stop functioning

= stop working properly

****失靈；故障；失效****

Examples

1. The brakes ****failed****.

煞車****失靈了****。

2. The power system ****failed**** during the storm.

暴風雨期間電力系統****故障了****。

Major distinct sense.

9. system / engine / equipment failure

= breakdown or loss of function

****系統 / 引擎 / 設備故障****

Examples

1. The accident was caused by engine ****failure****.

事故是由引擎****故障****造成的。

2. A system ****failure**** shut down the network.

系統****故障****令網絡停止運作。

Body / health

10. fail — body organ loses function

= gradually or suddenly stop working properly

****衰竭；失去功能****

Examples

1. His kidneys began to ****fail****.

他的腎臟開始****衰竭****。

2. The heart can ****fail**** under severe strain.

心臟在嚴重壓力下可能會****衰竭****。

Distinct medical sense.

11. failing health

= health that is gradually becoming weaker or worse

日漸衰弱的健康狀況

Examples

1. He retired because of **failing health**.

他因**健康日漸衰退**而退休。

2. Her **failing eyesight** made reading difficult.

她**逐漸衰退的視力**令閱讀變得困難。

Strength / memory / courage

12. fail — weaken or give way

= become weaker or stop being reliable

衰退；減弱；支撐不住

Examples

1. His memory began to **fail**.

他的記憶力開始**衰退**。

2. Her voice **failed** for a moment.

她的聲音一時**發不出來 / 變弱了**。

13. courage / nerve fails someone

= someone suddenly loses courage or confidence

突然失去勇氣；膽怯起來

Examples

1. His courage **failed him** at the last moment.

到了最後一刻，他突然**失去了勇氣**。

2. Her nerve **failed** just before she went on stage.
她上台前突然**怯場了**。

Let someone down

14. fail someone

= not give someone the help, support, or result they needed
辜負某人；使某人失望

Examples

1. I won't **fail you**.
我不會**辜負你**。

2. The system **failed the people** who depended on it.
這套制度**辜負了**依賴它的人。

Important figurative sense.

15. fail someone in a time of need

= not support someone when support is needed
在需要時沒有幫上某人；辜負某人

Examples

1. His friends did not **fail him** when he needed help.
他需要幫助時，朋友沒有**辜負他**。

2. She felt that the organization had **failed her**.
她覺得那個組織**辜負了她**。

Business / financial collapse

16. fail — business becomes unsuccessful and closes

= become unable to continue operating, often because of financial problems
倒閉；破產；經營失敗

Examples

1. Several small businesses **failed** during the recession.
經濟衰退期間有幾家小企業**倒閉**。
2. The company **failed** after losing its main customer.
公司失去主要客戶後**經營失敗並倒閉**。

17. business failure

= unsuccessful business, or collapse of a business

企業失敗；公司倒閉

Examples

1. Poor cash flow can lead to business **failure**.
現金流不足可能導致企業**倒閉**。
2. The entrepreneur learned from an earlier **failure**.
這位創業者從早期一次**失敗**中學習。

Duty / responsibility

18. fail in your duty

= not perform a responsibility properly

未盡責；失職

Examples

1. The manager **failed in his duty** to protect staff.
經理沒有盡到保護員工的責任，屬於**失職**。
2. The organization **failed in its responsibility** to act quickly.
該組織**未有履行責任**及時採取行動。

Supply / availability

19. crop / harvest fails

= crop does not grow successfully or produce enough food

****農作物歉收；收成失敗****

Examples

1. The crop ****failed**** because of drought.

農作物因乾旱而****歉收****。

2. If the harvest ****fails****, food prices may rise.

如果收成****失敗 / 歉收****，食品價格可能上升。

Established agricultural sense.

20. rains fail

= expected rain does not come

****雨水失常；久旱無雨****

Examples

1. The rains ****failed**** that year.

那一年****雨水失常，遲遲不下雨****。

2. Crops suffered when the seasonal rains ****failed****.

季節性雨水****沒有如期而至****，農作物因而受損。

Failure as noun

21. failure — lack of success

= situation in which someone or something does not succeed

****失敗****

Examples

1. The experiment ended in ****failure****.

實驗以****失敗****告終。

2. Fear of ****failure**** stopped him from trying.

對****失敗****的恐懼令他不敢嘗試。

22. failure — unsuccessful person/thing

= person, project, product, etc. considered unsuccessful

****失敗的人 / 事物****

Examples

1. The product was a commercial ****failure****.

這項產品在商業上是個****失敗****。

2. He viewed the project as a complete ****failure****.

他認為這個專案徹底****失敗****。

Be careful when applied to people: it can sound harsh.

23. failure — breakdown / loss of function

= instance of a machine, system, organ, etc. stopping functioning

****故障；失效；衰竭****

Examples

1. The outage was caused by equipment ****failure****.

停電是由設備****故障****造成的。

2. The patient suffered kidney ****failure****.

病人出現****腎衰竭****。

Failed adjective

24. failed — unsuccessful

= having attempted something but not succeeded

****失敗的；未成功的****

Examples

1. It was a ****failed attempt**** to solve the problem.

那是一次****失敗的嘗試****。

2. The negotiations followed several ****failed efforts****.

這次談判之前已有數次****未成功的嘗試****。

25. failed business / state / project

= business, organization, project, etc. that has ceased to function successfully

****失敗 / 失靈的企業、體制或專案****

Examples

1. He bought a ****failed business**** and rebuilt it.

他收購了一家****經營失敗的公司****並重新整頓。

2. The report examined several ****failed projects****.

報告研究了幾個****失敗的專案****。

Unfailing

26. unfailing

= always reliable, constant, or never ending

****始終如一的；可靠不變的****

Examples

1. She showed ****unfailing kindness****.

她始終展現出****不變的善意****。

2. He gave them his ****unfailing support****.

他一直給予他們****堅定不變的支持****。

Useful opposite-family extension.

High-value expressions

27. without fail

= certainly; every time; without exception

****一定；必定；每次都不例外****

Examples

1. Call me tomorrow **without fail**.
明天**一定要**打電話給我。
2. She arrives at eight every morning **without fail**.
她每天早上八點**準時出現，從不例外**。

Very high-value fixed expression.

28. never fail to do something

= always do something; something happens every time
總是會.....；從不會不.....

Examples

1. That song **never fails to make me smile**.
那首歌**每次都能讓我笑起來**。
2. He **never fails to surprise me**.
他**總能讓我感到驚訝**。

Interesting reversal of the basic meaning.

29. if all else fails

= if every other method or option is unsuccessful
如果其他方法全都失敗；萬一其他辦法都不行

Examples

1. **If all else fails**, call a technician.
如果其他辦法都行不通，就找技術人員。
2. We can take a taxi **if all else fails**.
實在沒有其他辦法的話，我們可以搭計程車。

30. fail-safe

A. designed to remain safe if part of it fails

****故障保安的；失效安全的****

1. The system has a ****fail-safe mechanism****.
系統有一個****故障保安機制****。

B. noun: backup safety mechanism

****安全保護機制****

2. An automatic shutdown acts as a ****fail-safe****.
自動關機是一種****安全保護機制****。

Key contrasts

31. fail vs lose

****fail****

= not succeed in achieving a goal or standard

****失敗；未達標****

****lose****

= be defeated, or no longer have something

****輸；失去****

Compare:

> fail an exam

> 考試不及格

> lose a game

> 輸掉比賽

32. fail vs make a mistake

****make a mistake****

= do one thing incorrectly

****犯錯****

****fail****

= not achieve the required result or objective

****失敗；未能做到****

One mistake does not necessarily mean failure.

33. fail vs miss

****miss****

= fail to notice, hit, reach, attend, or catch something

****錯過；沒看到；沒趕上****

****fail to****

= broad grammatical construction meaning “not manage to”

Compare:

> miss the bus

> 錯過巴士

> fail to catch the bus

> 未能趕上巴士

34. fail vs neglect

****fail to do****

= simply says something was not done

****未能 / 沒有做****

****neglect to do****

= suggests carelessness or failure of responsibility

****疏忽而沒有做****

Compare:

> He failed to reply.

> 他沒有回覆。

> He neglected to reply.

> 他疏忽了，沒有回覆。

35. fail vs malfunction

****malfunction****

= machine/system operates incorrectly

****故障；運作不正常****

****fail****

= can mean stop functioning altogether or become unable to perform its function

Compare:

> the sensor malfunctioned

> 感應器運作異常

> the brakes failed

> 煞車失靈

Meaning map

The central concept of ****fail**** is:

****not achieve the expected result or function****

From this develop:

General goal

the plan fails

→ ****計畫失敗****

Passage

fail to see

→ ****未能看見 / 沒有意識到****

Education

fail an exam

→ ****考試不及格****

Machine

brakes fail

→ ****煞車失靈****

Body

kidneys fail

→ **腎臟衰竭**

Mental/physical ability

memory fails

→ **記憶力衰退**

Support

fail someone

→ **辜負某人**

Business

company fails

→ **公司倒閉**

Agriculture

crop fails

→ **農作物歉收**

The passage uses the **fail to + verb** branch:

> **fail to see the value**

> → **未能看見 / 沒有意識到價值**

MCQ-ready master list

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
fail — not succeed	沒有達到目標或預期結果；失敗
fail at something	在某件事上做不成功 / 失敗
fail to do something	未能完成或沒有做到某事
fail to see/realize/understand	沒有看出、意識到或理解某事
fail — exam/test	考試、測驗或課程不及格
fail someone — exam	判某人不及格
fail — machine/system	機器、系統等停止正常運作；失靈 / 故障
failure — machine/system	設備或系統的故障 / 失效
fail — organ/body	身體器官停止正常運作；衰竭
failing health/eyesight	健康、視力等逐漸衰弱 / 惡化

memory/voice fails	記憶、聲音、力量等開始衰退或突然不起作用	
courage/nerve fails someone	某人在關鍵時刻突然失去勇氣	
fail someone — support	沒有給予所需幫助 / 支持；辜負某人	
fail in your duty	沒有履行應有責任；失職	
fail — business	企業因經營或財務問題而倒閉 / 失敗	
business failure	商業上的失敗 / 企業倒閉	
crop/harvest fails	農作物未能正常生長或收成不足；歉收	
rains fail	預期的雨水沒有到來	
failure — lack of success	沒有成功的結果 / 失敗	
failure — unsuccessful thing/person	被認為沒有成功的人或事物	
failure — breakdown	機器、系統、器官等失效 / 故障 / 衰竭	
failed — unsuccessful	嘗試過但未成功的	
unfailing	始終可靠、不變、持續的	
without fail	一定；毫無例外地；每次都	
never fail to do	每次都會做某事；總是能.....	
if all else fails	如果其他所有方法都不奏效	
fail-safe	在故障時仍保持安全的；故障保安機制	

Passage recap

> “...sometimes we are so busy chasing what might have been that we ****fail to see**** the value of what is already in front of us.”

Here:

****fail to see**** = ****not manage to recognize, notice, or appreciate something****

Best Traditional Chinese:

* ****沒有看見****

* ****未能意識到****

* ****忽略了****

* contextually: ****看不到其價值****

Natural contextual translation:

****有時候我們太忙著追逐那些「本來可以怎樣」的可能，反而未能看見眼前已經擁有的價值。****

Passage MCQ-ready meaning

****fail to do something****

= ****not manage to do something, or not do something that should or could have been done****

****未能做某事；沒有做到某事****

The key distinction is:

> **fail an exam**

> → 考試不及格

> **a machine fails**

> → 機器失靈

> **a business fails**

> → 公司經營失敗 / 倒閉

but in the passage:

> **fail to see**

> → **沒有看見 / 未能意識到**

So **fail** here does not mean that the person is generally a failure. It simply marks a **failure to perform one mental action: recognizing the value already present**.